

Silence and Implication Lab Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 20-30 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	silence-and-implication-lab

Big idea: Meaning often depends on implication; silence can communicate without explicitly claiming.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students analyze how what is left unsaid can communicate assumptions, politeness, doubt, or power.

Student Prompt

Inspect Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Dialogue: 'Did you like my presentation?' 'Well, your slides were very colorful.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Dialogue: 'Are you coming to the meeting?' 'I have a lot of homework tonight.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Silence and Implication Lab Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Dialogue: 'Are you coming to the meeting?' 'I have a lot of homework tonight.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Meaning often depends on implication; silence can communicate without explicitly claiming.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
6	Can silence be evidence?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Language.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how meaning often depends on implication; silence can communicate without explicitly claiming.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: Can silence be evidence?

Setup Checklist

- Use brief dialogues with simple social contexts.
- Remind students that implication depends on shared norms and can be misread.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- Dialogue: 'Did you like my presentation?' 'Well, your slides were very colorful.'
- Dialogue: 'Are you coming to the meeting?' 'I have a lot of homework tonight.'

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/silence-and-implication-lab/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/silence-and-implication-lab/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/silence-and-implication-lab/visual-prompt.svg>
- Explicit/implied meaning chart.
- Context cards: close friend, teacher feedback, formal email, sarcastic tone, nervous speaker.

Run Sequence

1. Give pairs a short dialogue with one ambiguous silence or indirect reply.
2. Students list what was explicitly said and what was implied.
3. Groups add context cards that change the implication.
4. Students decide which interpretation is most justified.
5. Debrief how implication functions in everyday and institutional knowledge.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: Can silence be evidence?
- How do context and shared norms make implication possible?
- When is reading between the lines responsible and when is it overinterpretation?

Teacher Quick Script

- What was said, what was implied, and what did you add?
- Which context clues justify your reading?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...